NAIF: Responsible research assessment and metadata quality at Swiss higher education institutions

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Overview

The **NAIF** project (National Approach for Interoperable Repositories and Findable Research Results) is a swissuniversities-funded collaboration led by ETH Library with seven Swiss higher education partners.

This poster combines **Track 1** on responsible research assessment and **Track 4** on academic metadata quality. Its core message is direct: **responsible indicators and interoperable repositories require the same curated metadata foundation**.

Evidence base

Track 1: Responsible assessment

- Workshop with **27 stakeholders** from Swiss higher education institutions, policy bodies, and the wider scientometrics community.
- Discussion of current indicator use, implementation barriers, and institutional needs.
- Framed by **DORA**, **CoARA**, and the **Leiden Manifesto**.

Track 4: Metadata quality

- Workshops with repository managers, data stewards, and open science specialists from across Switzerland.
- Focus on organisational, researcher, funding, and open access metadata.
- Prioritisation of practical actions for curation, workflows, and cross-institution coordination.

Key messages

Aspect	Insight
Reform momentum	Swiss institutions increasingly align with DORA and CoARA, but implementation remains uneven.
Responsible indicators	Quantitative indicators must be transparent, contextual, and fair.
Preferred use	Organisational monitoring is generally more appropriate than individual benchmarking.
Metadata priorities	ROR and ORCID alignment, funding metadata, and open access metadata are the most actionable improvement areas.

Acknowledgements

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Contact

NAIF Tracks 1 and 4 Responsible research assessment and academic metadata
eth-library.github.io/naif

Partner Institutions

ETH zürich – ETH Library
Universität Zürich[UZH]
EPFL
zhaw
PH SG
UNI FR
unine Université de Neuchâtel
Universität St.Gallen
swissuniversities

Q1: Why connect assessment and metadata?

- Repositories increasingly support **discovery**, **open science monitoring**, **policy reporting**, and sometimes **evaluation**.
- Incomplete or inconsistent records reduce findability and weaken interpretation.
- Metadata quality is therefore not only a technical issue; it is a precondition for **responsible research assessment**.

Q2: Which metadata families matter most?

Metadata family	Why it matters
Organisational metadata	Disambiguates institutions and units, supports aggregation, and improves cross-system linking.
Researcher metadata	Connects outputs reliably to people and reduces ambiguity in authorship data.
Funding metadata	Links outputs to grants and programmes, making public investment more visible and interpretable.
Open access metadata	Clarifies dissemination routes, access conditions, and monitoring categories.

These four families provide the **contextual backbone** for repositories, discovery services, and assessment workflows.

Q3: What did Swiss stakeholders emphasise?

- Indicators must be **transparent**, **context-specific**, and **fair**.
- Quantitative metrics should **complement expert judgement**, not replace it.
- **Organisational monitoring** is generally preferable to individual performance ranking.
- **Data quality is non-negotiable**: source transparency, documentation, and curation are prerequisites for meaningful indicators.
- Academic libraries are central because they maintain trusted metadata and document its limits.

Q4: What can academic libraries do now?

- Improve institutional name disambiguation and **ROR** alignment.
- Strengthen **ORCID** integration in repository and CRIS workflows.
- Standardise the capture of **funding** and **open access** metadata at deposit stage.
- Maintain shared mappings for organisational hierarchies and local structures.
- Connect metadata curation more closely with local assessment and reporting needs.

Conclusion and key takeaways

NAIF will deliver practical guidance by the end of 2026. For libraries, the message is clear: **better metadata improve discovery and make evaluation more fair, transparent, and interpretable**.

	Takeaway
1	Libraries curate infrastructure for both visibility and assessment.
2	Responsible indicators depend on trustworthy metadata.
3	Organisational, researcher, funding, and open access

	Takeaway
	metadata provide essential context.
4	Shared governance is needed to sustain metadata quality across institutions.